

The Art of War

Sun Tzu

I. Laying Plans

The art of war is of vital importance to the State. It is a matter of life and death, a road either to safety or to ruin. Hence it is a subject of inquiry which can on no account be neglected. The art of war is governed by five constant factors: the Moral Law, Heaven, Earth, the Commander, and Method and Discipline. All warfare is based on deception. Hence, when able to attack, we must seem unable; when using our forces, we must seem inactive.

II. Waging War

When you engage in actual fighting, if victory is long in coming, then the weapons will grow dull and ardor will be damped. There is no instance of a country having benefited from prolonged warfare. The skillful soldier does not raise a second levy, neither are his supply wagons loaded more than twice.

III. Attack by Stratagem

Supreme excellence consists in breaking the resistance without fighting. Thus the highest form of generalship is to balk the plans; the next best is to prevent the junction of the forces. If you know the enemy and know yourself, you need not fear the result of a hundred battles.

IV. Tactical Dispositions

The good fighters of old first put themselves beyond the possibility of defeat, and then waited for an opportunity of defeating the enemy. To secure ourselves against defeat lies in our own hands, but the opportunity of defeating the enemy is provided by the enemy himself.

V. Energy

The control of a large force is the same principle as the control of a few men: it is merely a question of dividing up their numbers. Indirect tactics, efficiently applied, are inexhaustible as Heaven and Earth, unending as the flow of rivers and streams.

VI. Weak Points and Strong

Whoever is first in the field and awaits the coming of the enemy will be fresh for the fight; whoever is second in the field and has to hasten to battle will arrive exhausted. Therefore the clever combatant imposes his will on the enemy, but does not allow the will of the enemy to be imposed on him.